

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Mauryan source hierarchy

CONTEMPORARY: Ashokan edicts -> royal voice, command and self-presentation

MATERIAL: sites, pillars, caves, coins -> context, craft and circulation

FRAGMENTARY: Megasthenes via later authors -> court and ethnographic reports

NORMATIVE: Arthashastra -> statecraft possibilities, not a Mauryan manual

TRADITION: Buddhist, Jaina, Puranic accounts -> dynastic and religious memory

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Strong claim = convergence across source classes + stated audience and limit.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Dynastic chronology and ruler differentiation

c. 324/321 BCE Chandragupta: foundation after Nandas
c. 305-301 BCE Seleucus conflict and treaty tradition
c. 300/297-273 Bindusara: continuity, limited direct evidence
c. 268/273-232 Ashoka: inscriptions, Kalinga and dhamma
232-c. 187/185 Later Mauryas; evidence becomes thin
Accession and consecration dates can differ.
Kalinga followed eight completed years after consecration.
Do not convert alternative chronologies into one false exact sequence.

ASCHII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Imperial geography: scale with differentiated control

PATALIPUTRA / GANGA CORE

- |-- Taxila / north-west

- |-- Ujjain / western routes

- |-- Tosali / Kalinga

- `-- Suvarnagiri / southern zone

EDICT DISTRIBUTION -> communication reach, not a cadastral frontier

CORE + PROVINCES + FRONTIERS + ALLIED/PERIPHERAL ZONES

Virtually subcontinental ambition coexisted with uneven administrative depth.

ASCI MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Administrative chain and local mediation

KING AND CENTRAL COURT

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princes / provincial centres

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mahamattas -> pradeshikas -> rajukas -> yuktas

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local officials, householders, guilds and communities

Hierarchy enabled scale; intermediaries created adaptation and information gaps.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Revenue, army and political economy

AGRICULTURE + TRADE + MINES/FORESTS + DUES

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REVENUE

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army + officials + roads + reservoirs + royal establishments

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security and integration can enlarge production and exchange

CAUTION: Arthashastra detail is prescriptive; actual rates and control varied.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Ashokan inscriptional communication

ROYAL MESSAGE

- |-- Major Rock Edicts: broad policy and dhamma
- |-- Minor Rock Edicts: personal religious commitment
- |-- Pillar Edicts: mature governance and dhamma
- |-- Separate Kalinga Edicts: provincial justice and confidence
- `-- Cave/dedication records: patronage

Prakrit-Brahmi predominates; Kharosthi, Greek and Aramaic mark adaptation.
An edict proves communication effort, not uniform reception or enforcement.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Dhamma: ethical governance and imperial mechanism

DIVERSE EMPIRE + SOCIAL CONFLICT + ROYAL PATERNALISM

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respect for elders + non-injury + sectarian restraint + welfare + self-control

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dhamma-mahamattas + tours + edicts + oral proclamation

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ethical legitimation and social concord within continuing monarchy

LIMIT: not a constitution, compulsory conversion or abandonment of Buddhism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Kalinga: remorse without disappearance of coercion

KALINGA WAR -> deaths, deportation and suffering in Rock Edict XIII

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remorse + preference for dhamma-vijaya

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yet army, punishment, capital penalty and forest warning remain

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VERDICT: ethical reorientation constrained conquest; it did not dissolve the state.

TRAP: Kalinga did not cause an instant first conversion to Buddhism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Mauryan art and monumental statecraft

PILLARS: monolithic shafts + polished stone + animal capitals + inscriptions

STUPAS: Ashokan cores later enlarged and embellished

CAVES: Barabar patronage and polished interiors

PALACE/CITY: Pataliputra and Kumhrar evidence with dating/function cautions

POPULAR ART: terracottas and large stone figures with disputed labels

INFLUENCE: Achaemenid/Hellenistic comparisons + distinctive Mauryan transformation

Monuments communicated power, patronage and dhamma across selected landscapes.

Date every layer separately; visible monuments are often multi-period.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: External relations and frontier diplomacy

CHANDRAGUPTA <-> SELEUCUS: conflict, treaty and diplomatic tradition

MEGASTHENES -> Mauryan court observation through later quotations

BINDUSARA -> Hellenistic diplomatic traditions with thin evidence

ASHOKA -> named Hellenistic kings in edictal moral geography

NORTH-WEST -> Greek and Aramaic inscriptions

SOUTH/FRONTIERS -> Cholas, Pandyas and others named beyond direct core rule

Diplomacy joined military security, trade routes and royal prestige.

Do not turn named neighbours into proven annexed provinces.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Centralisation debate and Arthashastra trap

STRONG CENTRAL MODEL

large army and officer lists

revenue and royal commands

Arthashastra possibilities

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\-- SYNTHESIS ---/

DIFFERENTIATED MODEL

distance and slow communication

provinces and local intermediaries

archaeology and regional variation

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Selective high capacity at strategic nodes, uneven depth elsewhere.

Arthashastra sharpens questions; it cannot be copied as an organisation chart.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Examiner-ready Mauryan answer spine

INTRO: define the empire through source plurality and differentiated scale.

BODY 1: rulers, chronology and geography

BODY 2: administration, revenue, army and local mediation

BODY 3: Ashokan inscriptions, Kalinga and dhamma

BODY 4: art, economy, external relations and regional variation

COUNTER: source bias, Arthashastra limits and intention-versus-practice gap

CONCLUSION: unprecedented scale and communication, but not uniform control.

WRITE: claim -> edict/site/text -> mechanism -> qualification.